

If you are switching to head-tracked Spatial Audio, then my friend, you are in for some rather unspectacular surprises.

With that out of the way, let's look at how the Apple AirPods 4 fared in terms of their ANC. While I did not get the best possible fit at all times, when I managed to push them into my ears to get me a decent enough seal, my mind was blown away by the ANC capabilities of these earphones. Thanks to the H2 chip, which is under the hood of Apple's other flagships, you understand why Apple would dare to take the leap and add ANC to these earphones, which have a half-in-ear design.

On a recent flight, I carried my AirPods Pro 2nd Gen and the AirPods 4 to test, and the difference between the performance of the two, when the AirPods 4 had a good seal, was minimal. So, once you have tried them out and ensured that you are getting a good fit, the Apple AirPods 4 will not let you down with their ANC. Lastly, the microphone performance of the Apple AirPods 4. What took me aback was their performance in the noisy office environment. When I was speaking rather quietly, the earphones picked a lot of noise around me, but when I was loud, to the point where I saw a few eyebrows raised around me, the earbuds cancelled noise as well as they did in most other environments.

BATTERY LIFE

In terms of the battery life, there is not much to write home about. I can call it mediocre at best. Apple claims that these earphones will last up to 4 hours on a single charge with ANC on, and it came fairly close to matching what is already a mediocre battery life claim to begin with.

In my tests, where I played a plink noise loop on these earbuds with ANC on and volume set to 50 per cent, the AirPods 4 lasted around 3.5 hours, which is honestly disappointing. Add the other trinkets, like Spatial Audio with head tracking and Adaptive Audio, and you will see barely 2.5 to 3 hours of battery life. At least, that is what my mileage was in my time of use.

VERDICT

The bottom line with the Apple AirPods 4 is – Only buy it if you want to stay in the

FEATURE	REMARKS
Noise Control	You get four levels of noise control on the AirPods 4 with ANC - Off, Transparency, Adaptive, and Noise Cancellation. I will dive deep into the performance of these three modes in the next section, but the implementation of these features and the ease of switching from the Control Centre or the earbuds is quite fast and intuitive.
Control Customisation	In terms of control customisation, you get little. You can only change the press-and-hold action on either earbuds, to either switch between noise control modes or triggering Siri.
Personalised Volume	It adjusts the volume of your AirPods depending on the noise around you. When in use, it works well, but it takes some time to get used to, and the volume shifts can feel a bit jarring at first. However, if you are looking at conserving battery life, then I would say, keep it turned off.
Conversational Awareness	Conversational awareness works along the same lines as personalised volume, but it lowers the media volume and cuts down on background noise when you are speaking. Well implemented, but I could not fit it into my daily routine. I would rather take my earphones out.
Adaptive Audio	Again, on principle, it is the same as the personalised volume feature or conversational awareness. It dynamically responds to your environment and lets you control whether to let in more or less noise depending on your preference. It is definitely a great to have for the times when you are out for a walk on the road.
Personalised Spatial Audio	This needs no introduction. Personalised spatial audio builds a virtual soundstage around you. And, it definitely is a great addition to movie watch sessions.
Head Gestures	Honestly, very quirky when you use it. They work surprisingly well, but you will attract a few eyeballs when accepting or rejecting calls.
Optimised Battery Charging	I have been seeing more and more manufacturers in the audio space implementing this, and given the lack of repairability of these devices, it is a great feature, which will not only help you increase the overall performance of the battery, but also prevent your AirPods from finding their place in a landfill within a couple of years of your buying them.

Apple Ecosystem and do not want to spend an arm and a leg for a pair of the Apple AirPods Pro 2nd Generation, which two years after its launch is retailing only a couple of thousand bucks off its launch price. Or you cannot stand TWS with in-ear design and you own an iPhone or a Mac or an iPad.

The fit is tricky to sit well with a majority of people; the case has a glossy finish, which attracts a lot of scratches, and the battery life is mediocre at best. What you are getting is fairly solid sound and ANC for a pair of half-in-ear earphones. If you are willing to spend ₹17,900 for this, please don't. Buy a cheaper pair of TWS earphones with a half-in-ear design like the Nothing Ear (stick), or just go for a

much better sounding and widely compatible pair like the Samsung Galaxy Buds Pro2 (which is MUCH cheaper than the AirPods or the Sony WF-1000XM5, which are literally the best pair of earphones you can get your hands on under 20K if you manage to get the right offers online, at least at the time of writing.

–Sativik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Bluetooth Version: 5.3 | Chipset: H2 | Battery Life: 5 hours without ANC, 4 hours with ANC | ANC: Yes | Features: Personalised Spatial Audio, Adaptive Audio, Transparency | IP Rating: IP 54

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